ing its credibility with the electorate, the Congress is struggling to maintain unity within its ranks. The AAP has already poached a sitting MLA and a former one—Raj Kumar Chabbewal and Gurpreet Singh G.P.—fielding them from Hoshiarpur and Fatehgarh Sahib, respectively. Internal bickering persists over the party's decision to field turncoat Jeet Mohinder Singh Sidhu in Bathinda and shift another party-hopper, Bholath MLA Sukhpal Singh Khaira, to Sangrur. Meanwhile, the BJP, eyeing an expansion in the state, has lured two sitting Congress MPs—Ravneet Singh Bittu (Ludhiana) and Preneet Kaur (Patiala)—to contest from their respective constituencies. The latter's crossover was a mere formality, of course, she being the wife of Capt. Amarinder and under suspension due to "anti-party activities" since last February. Not to be outdone, the Akali Dal has roped in former Punjab Congress chief Mohinder Singh Kaypee as its candidate from Jalandhar. Partap Singh Bajwa, the Leader of Opposition in the Punjab assembly, terms it "good riddance", claiming that the departure of these leaders has given the party a chance to field fresh faces. Among the eight Congress winners in 2019, only two—Gurjeet Singh Aujla (Amritsar) and Amar Singh (Fatehgarh Sahib)—have been retained, while Manish Tewari (Anandpur Sahib) has been shifted to Chandigarh, and Jasbir Singh Gill (Khadoor Sahib) has opted out.

## AAP: Issues Galore

But when it comes to the failure to put its own house in order, the biggest embarrassment was reserved for the AAP. In mid-April, a video surfaced of AAP legislator Kunwar Vijay Pratap Singh alleging that two police officers involved in the drug trade in Amritsar are close to a Rajya Sabha MP of the party, igniting a major controversy and touching upon the raw nerve of the electorate's frustration with the unresolved drug menace.

The 2022 verdict, which saw the AAP storming to power, was driven by voter fatigue with the conventional leadership's failure to address legacy issues like drugs, law and order, dwindling economy, Panthic matters and farmers' protests. Two years later, the Mann regime finds itself grappling with these unresolved issues: drugs are still a potent concern, farm unions continue to be up in arms, the state is caught in a debt trap, and Panthic demands—including justice for the 2015 sacrilege incidents and the release of Khalistani militants convicted for their involvement in violence during the insurgency in Punjab—remain unfulfilled. Agitated farm unions, dissatisfied with both the BJP-led Union government, for its failure to commit to a legal framework for the minimum support price (MSP), and the Mann regime, for not taking up their cause effectively, have been regularly disrupting campaigns of both the parties.



**AS A LAST-DITCH EFFORT, AKALI DAL CHIEF SUKHBIR BADAL TRIED TO RETURN TO THE NDA FOLD. BUT THE BJP SHUT THAT DOOR, CITING HIS ADAMANT STANCE ON PUSHING FOR THE RELEASE OF CONVICTED KHALISTANI MILITANTS**

The AAP, which has declared its candidates for all 13 seats, has fielded five state cabinet ministers, three sitting legislators and three turncoats besides singer-comedian Karamjit Anmol (Faridkot). Malvinder Singh Kang, the party spokesperson and candidate from Anandpur Sahib, calls it a "tactical move", as the party is new and doesn't have a pool of recognisable faces.

Notably, the Punjab AAP is attempting to project itself as a sub-regional front, carrying on its campaign in the name of Bhagwant Mann rather than the national party supremo Arvind Kejriwal. The slogan it has chosen says it all: '*Sansad vich vi Bhagwant Mann, khushhal Punjab te vadegi shaan* (With Bhagwant Mann even in Parliament, Punjab will prosper with grandeur)'. In fact, after Kejriwal's arrest in the Delhi excise policy case, the response from the party's Punjab unit has been quite muted, as though distancing itself from the entire controversy. But the AAP's woes have been compounded after its sole sitting Lok Sabha MP Sushil Kumar Rinku, who won the Jalandhar bypoll in 2023, defected to the BJP in late March.

## BJP: Calculated Moves

Lacking a robust grassroots machinery, the BJP, besides defections, is banking heavily on the urban voters' perceived attraction to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the emotive undercurrent surrounding the construction of the Ram temple. This urban-centric strategy gained urgency after the BJP's efforts to make inroads into the rural Jat Sikh vote bank floundered, despite roping in former Punjab Congress president Sunil Jakhar as its state unit chief.

In Amritsar, the party has fielded Taranjit Sandhu, a Jat Sikh and the previous ambassador to the US, in a calculated move to appeal to both the rural and urban youth elector. While trying to break new ground, it is also consolidating its existing support base by fielding old-timers, like two-time legislator Dinesh Singh Babu from Gurdaspur. In Hoshiarpur, while dropping Union